

SECTION FOURTEEN

INSTITUTIONS & STRUCTURES

Institutions aren't just settings. They're systems built to control, rank, test, and bind people, and in romantasy, the right institution becomes something wonderful for your story: a container your characters can't escape from. An institution will force characters to spend time together, build hierarchies they have to navigate, and create consequences that make leaving impossible or genuinely dangerous.

An institutional setting also has built-in rules, schedules, and power structures. Your characters can't just walk away from an academy mid-semester or abandon a military post during wartime. The institution creates the box; your job is to make sure that box compresses your characters together.

This section continues to build upon the political structures from Section 5 (Government), the cultural expectations from Section 3 (Culture), and the economic bindings from Section 4 (Economy). Here, we're focusing specifically on how institutions function as romantic pressure systems.

The Institutional Grip Principle

An institution only works for your romance if it has grip.

Grip means your characters genuinely can't leave. Not "it would be inconvenient to leave" or "they'd feel guilty about leaving," but the institution has real, enforceable power over their lives. The academy will kill them if they fail. The courts will destroy their family if they step out of line. The military will execute them for desertion. The marriage contract is magically binding and can never be broken. There are no keys to unlock the cages.

It is the grip of the institution that allows everything else to happen. When the institution has real teeth, every stolen moment between your characters carries weight. What would normally be a flirtatious conversation late at night is now a risk of being expelled. A kiss in the wrong corridor isn't just romance; it's risking everything they've built. The institution takes something that normally occurs between lovers and makes it an act of rebellion, and rebels are very appealing to read about.

However, the most easily overlooked element is this: the institution shouldn't just determine whether your characters can be together. It should shape how they love each other. Because of the ranking system at the academy, she has to beat him in combat trials while wanting to kiss him. Due to the court's surveillance, they express their feelings through coded glances and plausible deniability. In the military, because of the chain of command, he gives her orders in public and falls apart in private. The institution doesn't just forbid the relationship; it defines the specific shape the relationship has to take in order to survive.

This is the grip. The institution's rules become the grammar of the love story. When those rules break down, or when your characters figure out how to live outside of them, it means something to the reader, because the reader felt the weight of every rule leading up to it.

How does your institution shape the way your characters express love?

The institution doesn't just forbid the relationship — it determines what the relationship looks like. Court characters love in coded glances; military characters love through orders and obedience; academy characters love through competition and grudging admiration. What specific behaviours, rituals, or workarounds does your institution force your characters to adopt?

The way they communicate feelings (coded, stolen, indirect):

YOUR ANSWER

The way they find physical closeness (what excuse the institution gives them):

YOUR ANSWER

The way institutional rules become the “grammar” of their relationship:

YOUR ANSWER

How to Think About Institutions in Romantasy

Institutions come in many forms. Some stories use a single institution; others combine elements. Before diving into specifics, identify what type of institution shapes your story:

Primary institution type:

- ☐ Academy/Training Ground (education, magical training, warrior school)
- ☐ Court/Palace (political centre, noble society)
- ☐ Military/Wartime (army, navy, resistance, occupation)
- ☐ Religious Order (temple, monastery, priesthood)
- ☐ Economic/Labour (guild, apprenticeship, debt bondage, employment)
- ☐ Healing/Care (hospital, asylum, recovery)
- ☐ Prison/Captivity (imprisonment, hostage situation, magical confinement)
- ☐ Secret Society/Underground (resistance movement, thieves' guild, spy network, hidden order)
- ☐ Arranged Marriage (political alliance, forced union)
- ☐ Hybrid (combines multiple types)

If hybrid, what elements combine?

Example: A military academy combines military structure with an educational setting. A temple that trains warrior-priests combines religious and military. A royal court with magical rankings combines court politics with magical hierarchy.

YOUR HYBRID

YOUR ANSWER

A Note Before You Begin

Most of these institutional types will not be applicable to your story, and that's absolutely fine. If your world has an academy but a court doesn't exist, skip the court section. If your story uses an arranged marriage but no military, go straight there. The subsections are designed to be self-contained, so work through those areas that fit your world and ignore the rest. You can always come back to the others as your story evolves.

Which Tropes Does Your Institution Naturally Generate?

Different institutions may naturally foster different types of romantic relationships. You can certainly try to work against those natural pairings, but knowing which way your setting has a tendency to push will help.

You don't necessarily need your institution to develop into its "default" trope. But if you're writing an academy setting that somehow avoids all rivalry, proximity, and hierarchy, then ask yourself: are you getting the most out of your setting's advantages, or fighting them?

What tropes does your institution naturally generate?

Your institutional setting will push toward certain romantic dynamics. Knowing which ones helps you lean into your setting's strengths — or deliberately subvert them. Tick all that apply, then note which one(s) you're using.

TROPE	ACADEMY	COURT	MILITARY	RELIGIOUS	ECONOMIC	CAPTIVITY	ARRANGE MARRIAGE
<i>Forced proximity</i>	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
<i>Enemies to lovers</i>	✓	✓	✓			✓	✓
<i>Forbidden love</i>	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		

TROPE	ACADEMY	COURT	MILITARY	RELIGIOUS	ECONOMIC	CAPTIVITY	ARRANGE MARRIAGE
<i>Rivals to lovers</i>	✓	✓			✓		
<i>Power imbalance</i>		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
<i>Only one bed</i>	✓		✓			✓	✓
<i>Fake dating / performance</i>		✓					✓

Which trope(s) is your institution pushing toward?

WHICH TROPE(S) IS YOUR INSTITUTION PUSHING TOWARD?

Are you leaning into that, or deliberately subverting it? If subverting, what are you replacing it with?

There's nothing wrong with working against the grain, but make sure you're doing it on purpose and replacing the lost tension with something equally strong.

YOUR ANSWER

Common Mistakes

Mistake 1: The Institution Has No Teeth

What it looks like: Your academy, court, or military has rules on paper, but nothing actually happens when characters break them. The institution threatens consequences but never delivers. Characters sneak around, violate protocols, and defy authority with no real fallout. The only thing stopping them from walking away is guilt or mild awkwardness.

Why it hurts: If breaking the rules costs nothing, then following the rules means nothing. And if the institution's grip is weak, the romance loses its tension. "We shouldn't be together" only works as a story engine when "shouldn't" carries real weight. Your readers need to feel the danger every time your characters steal a moment together, and that danger has to come from the institution itself, not just from the characters feeling a bit nervous about it. Compare the Scholomance in Naomi Novik's series, where the school's protective mechanisms can and will kill you if you're careless, to an academy where the worst consequence for rule-breaking is a stern talking-to. One keeps you gripped. The other makes you wonder why the characters don't just leave.

How to fix it: Before you write a single scene of stolen intimacy, write down exactly what happens if they get caught. Not "someone would be disappointed" but the specific, named consequence. Expulsion. Execution. Exile. Loss of magic. The institution needs to have already punished someone for this exact thing, so the threat is proven, real, and not hypothetical.

Mistake 2: The Institution Disappears Mid-Story

What it looks like: The academy's ranking system, the court's surveillance, or the military's chain of command matters intensely in Act 1 but is quietly forgotten once the romance gets going. The characters still technically exist within the institution, but its rules, schedules, and hierarchies stop shaping their behaviour. The institution becomes wallpaper.

Why it hurts: The institution is supposed to be the pressure that makes the romance feel urgent and dangerous. When it fades into the background, you lose the container that was compressing your characters together. This is a version of what critics call "Main Character Syndrome" worldbuilding, where the external world stops reacting logically to the protagonists' actions because the author is focused on the emotional arc. In the ACOTAR series, for instance, the Night Court's governance structures and political responsibilities often vanish when the romantic plot takes centre stage, leaving a world that feels like it pauses when the main characters aren't looking at it.

How to fix it: At every major romantic beat, ask yourself: “What is the institution doing right now?” If your characters are having a secret midnight conversation in the academy, who’s doing bed checks? If they’re stealing a kiss at court, whose spy network just clocked it? The institution should be a constant presence that shapes *how* intimacy happens, not just *whether* it happens. The best romantic moments in these kinds of stories happen *because* of the institution’s pressure, not in spite of it.

Mistake 3: The Institution Is Generic

What it looks like: Your academy feels like every other fantasy academy. Your court could be swapped into any other romantasy with no changes. Your military doesn’t reflect your world’s specific magic, culture, or history. The institution is a stock setting with the serial numbers filed off.

Why it hurts: If readers have seen this exact institution before, they’ll predict every beat. More importantly, a generic institution can’t do the specific work your romance needs. The whole point of designing an institution is that *this* institution, with *these* rules and *this* hierarchy and *this* particular corruption, creates the exact pressure that forces *your* characters together in ways that wouldn’t happen anywhere else. In *The Cruel Prince*, Holly Black’s Fae court works because it operates on specifically Fae rules: they can’t lie, contracts are magically binding, and words are literal weapons. That’s not a generic court with pointed ears. It’s a political system whose unique constraints shape every romantic interaction Jude and Cardan have. Strip those rules away and the romance falls apart.

How to fix it: Take your institution and ask: “What about my world’s magic, culture, or history makes this institution different from the same type of institution in another book?” If your academy has a ranking system, what’s unique about how rankings work given your specific magic system? If your court has surveillance, is it magical or social or both, and how does that reflect your world’s particular power structures? The institution should be so embedded in your world that it couldn’t exist anywhere else.

The Academy/Training Ground

The academy setting is romantasy gold because it combines forced proximity, competitive rankings, and high stakes in one package. Think of Basgiath War College in *Fourth Wing*, where riders are put into squads they didn't choose, ranked against each other in deadly challenges, and paired with dragons who might kill them on sight. The academy does the heavy lifting: it forces Violet and Xaden into the same space, creates a complicated power dynamic (he's a wingleader; she's a first-year), and ensures that every interaction carries life-or-death weight. You don't have to manufacture reasons for your characters to keep running into each other when the institution's schedule does it for you.

The best academy settings don't just teach; they threaten. If your characters could coast through without real consequences, then the institution loses its grip on them. The danger is what forces characters to rely on each other, compete against each other, or protect each other when they shouldn't.

What kind of academy is it?

Magical training, military school, assassin academy, scholarly institution, religious education, craft guild school?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes your academy dangerous or high-stakes?

Deadly trials? Brutal competition? Magical dangers? Political intrigue? Secrets that could kill?

YOUR ANSWER

How long do students stay?

The length of time at the academy determines how much pressure builds. A single semester creates urgency; years create slow burn. The duration also affects how deeply the institution shapes your characters' identities.

YOUR ANSWER

Can students leave? What happens if they try to quit?

CAN STUDENTS LEAVE? WHAT HAPPENS IF THEY TRY TO QUIT?

The Ranking System

Does your academy have rankings? What determines rank?

Physical prowess, magical power, test scores, combat victories, political connections, instructor favour?

YOUR ANSWER

What do top-ranked students get? What happens to those at the bottom?

Example:

LEVEL	WHAT THEY GET	ROMANTIC IMPLICATION
<i>First year</i>	<i>Basic magic training, no outside contact, shared dormitories with four to a room</i>	<i>No privacy; every interaction is witnessed by roommates</i>
<i>Inner Circle (fourth-year)</i>	<i>Private chambers, direct access to the Archmage</i>	<i>Private space exists but is earned; the gap between ranks creates longing and barriers</i>

Your academy's ranking structure:

RANK/LEVEL	WHAT THEY GET OR LOSE	HOW THIS AFFECTS THE ROMANCE
Privileges at the top:		
Consequences at the bottom:		
Where your protagonist sits:		
Where your love interest sits:		

How does ranking create tension between your characters?

Competing for the same spot? One at top, one struggling? Must choose between winning and helping each other? Assigned as partners despite rivalry?

YOUR ANSWER

Living Arrangements

Where do students sleep? How much privacy exists?

WHERE DO STUDENTS SLEEP? HOW MUCH PRIVACY EXISTS?

What daily routines force interaction?

Communal meals, training, shared bathing, curfews, inspections, study groups?

YOUR ANSWER

What rules govern relationships between students?

Forbidden entirely? Forbidden between certain ranks? Allowed but discouraged? Punishable how?

YOUR ANSWER

Authority & Mentorship

Who runs the academy? What power do instructors have over students?

WHO RUNS THE ACADEMY? WHAT POWER DO INSTRUCTORS HAVE OVER STUDENTS?

Is there a mentor figure who might help or hinder the relationship?

IS THERE A MENTOR FIGURE WHO MIGHT HELP OR HINDER THE RELATIONSHIP?

What would happen if an instructor discovered the relationship?

WHAT WOULD HAPPEN IF AN INSTRUCTOR DISCOVERED THE RELATIONSHIP?

Courts & Palaces

Court settings replace physical danger with social danger. Everything said is analysed, every glance is catalogued. Courts are excellent for slow-burn because intimacy must be stolen in brief moments. Jude can never merely speak to Cardan; every exchange occurs while being watched by a court that will destroy her for showing weakness or wanting the wrong person. The constraint isn't a locked door. It's knowing that one misread glance could unravel everything she's built. That's what makes court romance so tense: the characters are rarely in physical danger from each other, but they're in constant social danger from everyone else.

The danger doesn't have to be physical. Social ruin can be just as devastating in a court setting, and the threat of it keeps every interaction loaded with subtext. If your characters can't afford to be seen caring about each other, even a lingering look becomes an act of rebellion.

What makes your court dangerous?

Political assassination, social ruin, blackmail, magical surveillance, loss of favour, imprisonment?

YOUR ANSWER

Who watches everyone, and why?

The surveillance system determines what your characters can get away with. Magical scrying means nothing is truly private; a network of gossips means information travels unpredictably. The nature of the watching shapes how your characters steal their moments together.

Spies, rivals, servants who report, magical surveillance, gossips?

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if they were seen together inappropriately?

What defines “inappropriate” in your court? Private conversation? Touching? Being alone? Dancing too often?

YOUR ANSWER

Court Hierarchy

Where does each character rank in the court hierarchy?

(Reference Section 5 for class structures)

POSITION	DESCRIPTION
Queen’s Inner Circle (example)	Twelve advisors with private audience rights; love interest is the youngest member ever appointed, causing resentment

POSITION	DESCRIPTION
Lady-in-Waiting (example)	Protagonist's cover position; grants access to royal quarters but no political voice; must attend the princess constantly
Protagonist's position:	
Love interest's position:	

What spaces can each access? Where would they naturally encounter each other?

WHAT SPACES CAN EACH ACCESS? WHERE WOULD THEY NATURALLY ENCOUNTER EACH OTHER?

Where could they have a truly private conversation?

WHERE COULD THEY HAVE A TRULY PRIVATE CONVERSATION?

Court Customs

What rituals force interaction between people who'd otherwise avoid each other?

(Reference Section 3 for cultural customs) *Dances, ceremonies, negotiations, festivals, religious observances, political marriages?*

YOUR ANSWER

How could they use customs to steal intimacy while appearing to follow rules?

The dance that allows touch, the ceremony that requires standing close, the negotiation that puts them in the same room.

YOUR ANSWER

Factions & Reputation

What factions exist? Which side is each character on?

WHAT FACTIONS EXIST? WHICH SIDE IS EACH CHARACTER ON?

What would each lose if the relationship became public?

WHAT WOULD EACH LOSE IF THE RELATIONSHIP BECAME PUBLIC?

Is the threat of exposure used against them?

IS THE THREAT OF EXPOSURE USED AGAINST THEM?

Military & War Settings

War is an accelerator for everything. When you're facing death, all pretences fall away, and "we might die tomorrow" becomes a spark to create intimacy. The war in *Fourth Wing* isn't background noise; it's the reason Violet and Xaden are at Basgiath in the first place, and the reason every single flight they take could be their last. This sense of urgency does things to characters that peacetime can't: it makes them reckless with truths they'd normally guard, and desperate for connection they'd normally deny themselves.

(For warfare's political dimensions, see Section 5. Here we're focusing on how military settings function as romantic containers.)

Why War Works

What conflict is your world engaged in?

WHAT CONFLICT IS YOUR WORLD ENGAGED IN?

How imminent is the danger?

Cold war creates tension through paranoia and espionage — your characters steal intimacy in the gaps between suspicion. Active combat creates urgency through proximity to death — “we might not survive this” accelerates every confession. Each generates a different romantic flavour.

Cold war (tension, espionage) or active combat (battles, sieges)?

YOUR ANSWER

What does “we might die tomorrow” actually mean for them?

Is death a real possibility they face? How does this urgency affect what they’re willing to say or do?

YOUR ANSWER

Military Structure

What’s each character’s role?

Their military roles define the power dynamic. A commander and a soldier under her command face very different romantic obstacles than two soldiers of equal rank. The role also determines what each character has access to — information, movement, authority — and what they risk by loving the wrong person.

Soldier, commander, medic, strategist, prisoner, spy, conscript, mercenary, support staff?

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War Mage (example)	Love interest is assigned to protagonist's unit as magical support; outranks her in magic but answers to her in battle
Protagonist:	
Love interest:	

What rules govern relationships between ranks?

Forbidden between officers and enlisted? Required to report relationships? Subject to reassignment?

YOUR ANSWER

What if their relationship interfered with the mission?

WHAT IF THEIR RELATIONSHIP INTERFERED WITH THE MISSION?

Forced Proximity in War

Where do soldiers sleep, eat, recover?

Barracks, tents, ships, field camps; what privacy exists?

YOUR ANSWER

What situation forces them to rely on each other for survival?

WHAT SITUATION FORCES THEM TO RELY ON EACH OTHER FOR SURVIVAL?

What injury might one tend for the other?

WHAT INJURY MIGHT ONE TEND FOR THE OTHER?

Opposite Sides

If they're on opposing sides, what brought them into contact?

Capture, neutral ground, secret negotiations, undercover work, chance meeting?

YOUR ANSWER

What information does each have that could harm the other's side?

WHAT INFORMATION DOES EACH HAVE THAT COULD HARM THE OTHER'S SIDE?

What would each sacrifice to be together?

The weight of the sacrifice is what proves the love is real. If what they'd give up is trivial, the choice carries no tension. If it's everything — loyalty, identity, safety — then the reader understands just how much this person matters.

YOUR ANSWER

At what point does love become treason?

AT WHAT POINT DOES LOVE BECOME TREASON?

Religious Institutions

Temples, monasteries, and religious orders create unique pressure: vows that conflict with desire, sacred duties that demand sacrifice, communities where devotion is expected to eclipse personal attachment.

(For religious doctrine and beliefs, see Section 6. Here we're focusing on how religious institutions bind characters and complicate desire.)

The Religious Setting

What religious institution are your characters part of or connected to?

Temple, monastery, convent, religious order, pilgrimage site, sacred academy?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the institution's stated purpose?

Training priests? Preserving knowledge? Serving a deity? Healing? Protection? Isolation from the world?

YOUR ANSWER

What vows or commitments does the institution require?

Celibacy, obedience, poverty, silence, service, separation from family, renunciation of former identity?

YOUR ANSWER

Religious Conflict with Love

Does either character have vows that conflict with the relationship?

	SPIRITUAL CONSEQUENCE	SOCIAL CONSEQUENCE	PRACTICAL CONSEQUENCE
<i>Example: Vow of celibacy (priestess of the moon goddess)</i>	<i>Loss of divine connection; magic fades</i>	<i>Public disgrace; family disowns her</i>	<i>Expelled from temple; loses home and income</i>
Your character's vow:			

Is the relationship forbidden, or just complicated by religious duty?

IS THE RELATIONSHIP FORBIDDEN, OR JUST COMPLICATED BY RELIGIOUS DUTY?

What would the institution do if the relationship were discovered?

Expulsion? Punishment? Forced separation? Loss of position? Trial? Worse?

YOUR ANSWER

Faith & Desire

Does either character struggle between faith and feeling?

This internal conflict is what makes religious settings so powerful for romance. A character torn between devotion to their god and desire for another person carries a tension that no external obstacle can match — because the obstacle is inside them.

YOUR ANSWER

How do they reconcile (or fail to reconcile) devotion and desire?

HOW DO THEY RECONCILE (OR FAIL TO RECONCILE) DEVOTION AND DESIRE?

Is there a way to have both, the relationship and their faith?

Or must they choose? *(Reference Section 6 for how religion might adapt or condemn)*

YOUR ANSWER

Economic & Labour Institutions

Guilds, apprenticeships, indentured service, and debt bondage create obligation that binds as tightly as any lock.

(For economic systems generally, see Section 4. Here we're focusing on how economic institutions trap characters together and complicate the power dynamics of love.)

The Economic Binding

What economic institution binds your characters?

Guild membership, apprenticeship, indentured service, debt bondage, employment contract, family business obligation, trade partnership?

YOUR ANSWER

Why can't they simply leave?

Debt that must be repaid? Contract with penalties? No other options? Would lose everything they've worked for? Legal consequences?

YOUR ANSWER

How long are they bound?

Duration shapes the romance. A short-term bond creates urgency — they must figure out their feelings before the timer runs out. A lifetime bond forces them to find a way to coexist, which is slow burn territory.

YOUR ANSWER

Economic Hierarchy**What's the power structure?**

Master and apprentice? Employer and worker? Creditor and debtor? Guild ranks? Business partners with unequal stakes?

YOUR ANSWER

If there's a power imbalance, how does it affect the relationship?

Economic dependency creates a specific kind of romantic tension that's different from physical danger or social pressure. It's the "Do they want me or do they just need me?" dynamic. The more powerful person carries guilt about whether genuine feeling can exist when they hold someone's livelihood. The less powerful person carries pride, resentment, and the nagging question of whether their own feelings are real or survival instinct. As long as the imbalance exists neither can fully trust the

connection, which means the relationship can't truly deepen until the power dynamic shifts, or until both characters find a way to be honest about it.

Can they be equals, or does one have power over the other's livelihood? (*Reference Section 4 for economic power dynamics*)

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen to the less powerful person if the relationship ended badly?

WHAT WOULD HAPPEN TO THE LESS POWERFUL PERSON IF THE RELATIONSHIP ENDED BADLY?

Forced Proximity Through Work

What work forces them together?

Shared workspace, shared housing, required collaboration, travelling for business, dependent on the same clients?

YOUR ANSWER

What risks does workplace romance create?

Loss of position, scandal, accusations of favouritism, contract violation, guild expulsion?

YOUR ANSWER

Healing & Care Institutions

Hospitals, asylums, and recovery spaces create vulnerability by design. One person is weak; the other provides care. The intimacy of illness and healing is unique.

The Care Setting

What healing institution is involved?

Hospital, field medical tent, asylum, magical healing centre, quarantine, recovery house, private sickroom?

YOUR ANSWER

Why is one character there?

Injury, illness, magical affliction, mental health crisis, recovery from trauma, curse, poison?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the other character's role?

Their role determines the initial power dynamic. A professional healer carries duty and ethical boundaries. A fellow patient shares vulnerability. A reluctant caretaker brings resentment that can transform into tenderness. Each starting point shapes the arc differently.

Healer, fellow patient, visitor, guard, staff, reluctant caretaker?

YOUR ANSWER

Vulnerability & Intimacy

What makes the patient vulnerable?

Physical weakness, dependence, loss of privacy, inability to leave, altered mental state, need for constant care?

YOUR ANSWER

What intimate care creates connection?

Feeding, bathing, wound care, sitting vigil, sharing confined space, witnessing pain, providing comfort?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the power imbalance of caregiver/patient affect the relationship?

This is perhaps the most difficult dynamic to write well, because readers can identify the imbalance regardless of whether or not the characters recognise it. The caregiver has access to the patient's body and vulnerability in ways that wouldn't normally be permitted; the patient may develop feelings rooted in gratitude and dependence rather than genuine connection. The craft challenge is making sure the relationship earns its ground. The best versions of this trope build in moments where the vulnerable character shows strength despite their condition (sharp wit, fierce independence, refusing pity) and moments where the caregiver becomes vulnerable too (exhaustion, fear of loss, accidentally revealing too much of themselves during a long vigil). If the dynamic doesn't have a two-way emotional connection, then it's weak.

Can genuine connection form when one person is so vulnerable? Does the dynamic shift when recovery happens?

YOUR ANSWER

Recovery & Change

How does the patient change during recovery?

Recovery is transformation. The person who emerges isn't the person who was admitted, and the caregiver has witnessed the entire journey. That shared knowledge — of weakness, of growth, of the messy in-between — becomes a bond no one else can replicate.

What does the caregiver witness? What do they learn about each other?

WHAT DOES THE CAREGIVER WITNESS? WHAT DO THEY LEARN ABOUT EACH OTHER?

What happens when recovery is complete?

Does the connection survive when vulnerability ends? Does the relationship need to be rebuilt as equals?

YOUR ANSWER

Arranged Marriages & Political Alliances

The arranged marriage forces intimacy before trust. Strangers are expected to figure out how to do everything related to domestic life, be close physically, and deal with political pressure all at the same time. In *The Bridge Kingdom*, Lara marries Aren as part of a political alliance, but she's been trained since childhood to destroy his kingdom from within. Her marriage to him isn't just an inconvenience; it's a mission, and every moment of genuine connection threatens to unravel the plan she was raised to execute. I think that's why arranged marriage provides such rich romantasy territory: the institution demands performance (act like a couple), and somewhere in the performance, real feeling starts leaking through.

(For marriage laws and customs, see Sections 3 and 5. Here we're focusing on how arranged marriage functions as a romantic container.)

The Arrangement

Why is this marriage happening?

Peace treaty, alliance, joining bloodlines, claiming territory, preventing war, magical necessity, fulfilling prophecy?

YOUR ANSWER

Who arranged it? Do the characters have any say?

Whether the characters had input shapes their initial attitude toward each other. A marriage imposed without consent breeds resentment that must be overcome. A marriage they reluctantly agreed to carries guilt and second-guessing. Either way, the arrangement is the inciting incident of the romance.

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if they refuse?

WHAT HAPPENS IF THEY REFUSE?

The Binding

What makes the marriage unbreakable?

Legal contract, magical binding, political treaty, religious vow, family honour?

YOUR ANSWER

Can they live separately, or must they cohabit?

CAN THEY LIVE SEPARATELY, OR MUST THEY COHABITATE?

What intimacy is expected?

Public appearances, shared household, producing heirs, consummation, presenting a united front?

YOUR ANSWER

Starting Point

Does the story begin before or after the marriage?

Before means the arrangement is an obstacle to escape or accept. After means they're already bound and must learn to live together.

YOUR ANSWER

If already married, what's their relationship like at the start?

Strangers? Cold distance? Active hostility? Tentative curiosity? Grudging respect?

YOUR ANSWER

What begins to shift how they see each other?

WHAT BEGINS TO SHIFT HOW THEY SEE EACH OTHER?

Navigating Strangers-to-Lovers

What preconceptions does each have about the other?

WHAT PRECONCEPTIONS DOES EACH HAVE ABOUT THE OTHER?

What's the first thing that surprises them?

WHAT'S THE FIRST THING THAT SURPRISES THEM?

What domestic situation forces vulnerability?

Arranged marriages turn ordinary domestic life into an emotional minefield. Sharing a bedroom when you're strangers, seeing each other ill or afraid, navigating servants who report every interaction — these small, inescapable intimacies are where the walls start to crack.

Sharing a bedroom, seeing each other sick, navigating servants who report everything, facing a crisis together?

YOUR ANSWER

External Pressure

Who wants this marriage to succeed? Who wants it to fail?

WHO WANTS THIS MARRIAGE TO SUCCEED? WHO WANTS IT TO FAIL?

What public performance is required?

The performance is where arranged marriages get interesting for romance. Characters who must act like a couple in public start to blur the line between pretence and reality. Every performed kiss, every public hand-hold, every shared glance for the benefit of an audience — at some point, it stops being entirely fake, and neither of them can pinpoint when.

YOUR ANSWER

What happens behind closed doors when performance ends?

The gap between the public act and the private reality is where the real relationship lives. When the audience is gone and the masks come off, what remains? Awkward silence? Relief? The unsettling realisation that they miss the pretence?

YOUR ANSWER

Prison & Captivity

Captivity is one of romantasy’s most potent institutional settings because it strips everything else away. There are no social niceties, no schedules, no institutional hierarchy to navigate. There’s just two people, a locked door, and whatever power imbalance exists between them. This creates the ultimate setting for both intense proximity and vulnerability that other institutions take chapters to build; captivity gets there in a single scene.

This setting has deep roots. Gothic literature built entire genres around heroines confined in towers, manors, and dungeons, but modern romantasy has transformed the dynamic completely. The captive is no longer a passive victim waiting for rescue. Instead she’s an active agent, using her confinement as a catalyst for growth, information-gathering, and eventually overthrowing the systems that caged her. Think of Feyre Under the Mountain, Poppy as the veiled Maiden in *From Blood and Ash*, or Lara infiltrating Ithicana as a bride-spy in *The Bridge Kingdom*. Each of these women were forged inside the cage.

Types of Captivity

Not all confinement looks the same, and the type you choose shapes the romance differently.

CAPTIVITY TYPE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	ROMANTIC EFFECT
Physical dungeon	Literal imprisonment: cells, chains, stone walls. Feyre Under the Mountain in ACOTAR.	Raw survival. Intimacy is desperate, born from shared trauma. The captor who shows unexpected mercy becomes magnetic.
Gilded cage	Comfortable confinement disguised as protection or privilege. Feyre in the Spring Court, Emilia in the underworld in <i>Kingdom of the Wicked</i> .	Slow-building resentment. The captive must recognise the cage before she can fight it, and the love interest is often the one who helps her see the bars.

CAPTIVITY TYPE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	ROMANTIC EFFECT
Ritual isolation	Confinement enforced by religious or cultural duty. Poppy as the Maiden in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> .	The captive has been trained to accept her confinement as normal. The love interest's role is to make her question everything she was taught to believe.
Geographic imprisonment	Trapped by landscape rather than locks. Lara in Ithicana in <i>The Bridge Kingdom</i> , surrounded by storms, sharks, and impassable seas.	The captive and captor are equally trapped. Neither can leave, which forces cooperation and creates a "we're in this together" bond.
Magical binding	Tethered by spell, bond, or bargain. Emilia and Wrath's marriage bond in <i>Kingdom of the Wicked</i> , Feyre's bargain with Rhysand.	The binding is inescapable and intimate. It often reveals truths neither character wanted exposed, and the "I didn't choose this" resentment slowly becomes "I'm choosing to stay."

The Power Dynamic

The balance of power in a captivity romance is what determines if the story lives or dies. The dynamic is inherently unequal, and that's the point, but it can't stay unequal. If it does, you haven't written a romance; you've written a story that endorses the captor's control.

This is the essential question. In every successful captivity romance, the captive must gain some form of leverage, whether through discovering her own power (Feyre gaining High Lord abilities, Poppy discovering her Atlantian heritage, Emilia realising she's a Star Witch), through acquiring information the captor needs, or through the captor's own transformation from seeing the captive as a tool to

seeing her as a person. By the time the story ends, both parties must be able to see each other as equals. If they don't, you've got a control story, not a love story.

Who holds power at the start:	
What shifts the balance:	
When do they become equals:	
What proves the shift is real (not just the captor being "nicer"):	

Forced Proximity in Captivity

Captivity creates the most extreme version of forced proximity in romantasy. The characters can't retreat to separate lives at the end of the day. There's no break from each other.

What does the physical space of confinement look like?

Cell, palace, island, enchanted realm, warded room, travelling under guard?

YOUR ANSWER

What intimacy does confinement force?

Shared sleeping space, being seen at your worst (injured, ill, grieving, afraid), depending on each other for basic needs, witnessing each other's private moments?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the captive observe about the captor that she wouldn't see in any other context?

It's these private moments that dissolve the "villain" archetype. A captor who is publicly ruthless but privately kind, or exhausted, or conflicted, becomes a person rather than a monster. Lara watching Aren govern Ithicana with genuine care for his people. Poppy seeing Hawke's tender side beneath the flirtation. Feyre witnessing Rhysand's burden behind his mask of cruelty. All of these things only come into existence because the characters are confined together, and they're what make the reader believe the romantic connection is real.

The Betrayal Beat

Almost all captivity romances include a betrayal or reveal that resets the power dynamic. There will be some sort of revelation about who the captor really is, what the captive's true nature is, or why they were confined in the first place, and the connection that's been building has to survive the aftermath.

This can't happen through words alone. Trust is rebuilt through action, through risk, through one character choosing the other at personal cost. Lara going back to rescue Aren from her own father's palace. Casteel putting Poppy's wellbeing above his original mission. The redemption has to be earned, not declared.

What is the betrayal or reveal that resets your captivity dynamic?

Almost every captivity romance has a moment where something is revealed — a true identity, a hidden agenda, the real reason for confinement — that shatters the trust built so far. What is that moment for your characters, and how is trust rebuilt through action rather than words?

The reveal/betrayal:

YOUR ANSWER

How trust is rebuilt (what action, not words, proves it):

YOUR ANSWER

The Stockholm Syndrome Question

Your readers are going to want to know how the captive was able to move past being held captive, so you need to have an answer built into your story. Modern romantasy handles it through choice and consequence. The captive must, at some point, have a genuine opportunity to leave and choose to stay,

or choose to return. Not because she's been conditioned to, but because she's seen something real and decided it matters more than her freedom from this specific person.

Maas uses the Night Court as a counter-narrative to the Spring Court: Feyre chooses Rhysand's world of autonomy over Tamlin's world of safety. Jensen gives Lara a full escape; she returns to Ithicana not because she's bonded to Aren but because she's decided to fight for what's right. Armentrout builds Poppy's arc so that by the time she has the power to destroy Casteel, she has enough information to choose him freely.

It's essential that the choice is informed and free. The captive must know the full truth, have the power to leave, and choose to stay anyway. If you don't do this, you haven't resolved the power imbalance. You've just dressed it up.

When does your captive freely choose to stay (or return)?

Your reader needs to see a moment where the captive has full information, the genuine power to leave, and chooses to stay anyway. Without this, the romance reads as coercion, not love. Design that moment.

What truth does the captive now know:

YOUR ANSWER

What genuine escape option exists:

YOUR ANSWER

Why they choose to stay (not dependency or conditioning — a real reason):

YOUR ANSWER

Secret Societies & Underground Organisations

Resistance movements, thieves' guilds, spy networks, and hidden orders create a unique romantic pressure: the relationship exists inside a secret, and secrets bind people together in ways that ordinary proximity can't. When two characters share membership in something forbidden, every interaction carries double meaning. They have a public life and a hidden one, and the hidden life is where the real connection forms. The secrecy itself becomes intimate — knowing someone's true allegiance, covering for them, trusting them with information that could get you killed. That's not just proximity. That's a bond.

The danger in these settings isn't institutional punishment in the traditional sense. It's exposure. Discovery doesn't mean expulsion from an academy or demotion in a court. It means imprisonment, execution, or the destruction of everyone in the network. The stakes are existential, which means every stolen moment carries the weight of everyone else's survival too.

The Secret Organisation

What kind of secret organisation are your characters part of?

The type of organisation determines what's at stake. A resistance movement fighting tyranny carries moral weight. A thieves' guild operates on self-interest and loyalty codes. A spy network runs on deception. Each creates different romantic tension.

Resistance movement, thieves' guild, spy network, hidden magical order, underground religion, smuggling ring, assassin brotherhood, revolutionary cell?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the organisation's purpose? What are they working toward or against?

WHAT IS THE ORGANISATION'S PURPOSE? WHAT ARE THEY WORKING TOWARD OR AGAINST?

What happens if the organisation is discovered?

This is the institutional grip. The consequence of exposure must be severe enough that every interaction between your characters carries real risk — not just for them, but for everyone they're protecting.

YOUR ANSWER

Secrecy & Trust

How does someone join? What binds them to silence?

Oaths, magical bonds, mutual blackmail, shared guilt, initiation rituals? The binding mechanism determines how trapped your characters are.

YOUR ANSWER

Do both characters know each other's involvement from the start, or does one discover the other's secret?

If both know, the shared secret is an instant bond — “us against the world.” If one discovers the other's involvement, the discovery becomes a turning point: do they protect the secret, exploit it, or join?

YOUR ANSWER

What would betrayal look like, and what would it cost?

WHAT WOULD BETRAYAL LOOK LIKE, AND WHAT WOULD IT COST?

The Double Life

What public personas do your characters maintain?

The gap between the public mask and the private truth is where the romantic tension lives. A noblewoman who's secretly funding the resistance. A palace guard who's reporting to the underground. The person they pretend to be and the person they actually are — the love interest gets to see both.

	PUBLIC PERSONA	SECRET TRUTH
Example: Inej (Six of Crows)	Acrobat and performer	Wraith — the Dregs' spy and assassin
Protagonist:		
Love interest:		

Where do they meet in secret? What cover do they use?

WHERE DO THEY MEET IN SECRET? WHAT COVER DO THEY USE?

How does maintaining the double life affect their ability to be honest with each other?

Characters who spend their days performing a lie often struggle to stop performing, even with someone they trust. The habit of secrecy can become a barrier to genuine intimacy.

YOUR ANSWER

Institutional Ideals vs. Reality

Answer these for whichever institution type you're building.

Every institution claims to serve a purpose, and the gap between what it claims and what it actually does creates brilliant story opportunities. Basgiath War College in Fourth Wing claims to train the next generation of dragon riders to defend the kingdom; in reality, it's a brutal selection process that treats cadets as expendable. The Spring Court in ACOTAR presents itself as a safe haven of beauty and tradition; in reality, it's a gilded cage where Feyre's autonomy is slowly suffocated. Once your characters find out about that gap, it changes everything, not just how they see the institution, but how they see each other. Disappointment can be a strong bond. Two people who've both looked behind the same curtain share something no one else can understand.

What does your institution claim to do?

The stated mission, the noble purpose, what it tells the world:

YOUR ANSWER

What does it actually do?

The reality beneath the ideal: control, exploitation, preservation of power, something darker?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters believe in the institution's stated purpose?

Are they idealists who believe in the mission? Cynics who see the truth? One of each? Do their views change?

Protagonist:	
Love interest:	

What happens when they see behind the curtain?

When the gap between ideal and reality becomes undeniable:

YOUR ANSWER

Does disillusionment bring them together or create conflict?

Do they bond over shared revelation? Or does one still believe while the other has lost faith?

YOUR ANSWER

Gaming the System

Answer these for whichever institution type you're building.

Every institution has people who know how to work it, and people who suffer under it.

Who benefits from this institution?

Who has power, comfort, and advantage within the system?

YOUR ANSWER

Who suffers under it?

Who is exploited, trapped, or disadvantaged by the system?

YOUR ANSWER

Where are your characters in this hierarchy?

Are they beneficiaries, victims, or somewhere in between? Do their positions differ?

YOUR ANSWER

Who knows how to game the system?

Someone who knows the loopholes, who to bribe, how to bend rules.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters learn to work the system?

Do they find ways around the rules? Use the institution against itself?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there corruption they could exploit, or that threatens them?

Bribes, favouritism, blackmail, secret deals, people who can be bought.

YOUR ANSWER

When the Institution Ends

Graduation. The war's over. The court is dissolved. The contract expires. What then?

Institutions create the container for the relationship, and when that container is removed, the relationship has to survive on its own. Planning for this area of tension is important, because “were we only together because we were trapped?” is one of the most painful questions a character can ask.

Not because they love the institution, but because they fear what will happen to the relationship without it. The structure gave them excuses to be near each other, reasons to touch, justification for needing each other. Without it, they'd have to choose each other on purpose, and that's terrifying.

Does the institution end in your story, or does it persist?

DOES THE INSTITUTION END IN YOUR STORY, OR DOES IT PERSIST?

If the institution ends, what proves the relationship is real without it?

The scariest moment isn't the institution failing — it's the characters facing each other without any external reason to stay. What does your couple do when the cage door opens?

What the institution provided that they must now provide for themselves (excuses to be near, shared purpose, routines):

YOUR ANSWER

The moment that proves they're choosing each other, not the institution:

YOUR ANSWER

If the institution persists, what changes about how they exist within it?

They can't go back to the way things were before the relationship. Something has to shift — their rank, their public face, their willingness to break rules, or the institution itself.

YOUR ANSWER

If it persists, the characters must find a way to exist within it on new terms. If it ends, they must find a way to exist without it. Both are interesting. Neither is easy.

The Diagnostic Question

For whatever institution you've chosen:

If my characters tried to walk away right now, what would stop them?

If the answer is “nothing” or “they’d feel bad,” your institution doesn’t have enough grip.

Strong answers sound like:

- They’d be executed for desertion
- The magical bond would kill them both
- Their families would go to war
- They’d lose their only chance at survival/power/freedom
- The enemy would capture them immediately
- They’d be stripped of their magic and exiled
- Their people would be slaughtered without the alliance
- They’d be hunted as oath-breakers

Weak answers sound like:

- They’d feel guilty
- It would be awkward
- Someone might be disappointed

What is that cost in your story?

Name the specific consequences that make walking away impossible, not just inconvenient.

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

How does your institution reflect or enforce government structures (from Section 5)?

Does the institution serve the ruling power, challenge it, or operate in its shadow?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your institution reflect cultural values (from Section 3)?

What beliefs about honour, duty, family, or success does this institution embody or exploit?

YOUR ANSWER

How does economic power shape your institution (from Section 4)?

Who funds it, who profits from it, and who pays the price of its existence?

YOUR ANSWER

How does religion intersect with your institution (from Section 6)?

Does faith legitimise, condemn, or operate parallel to this institution's authority?

YOUR ANSWER

How does magic affect how the institution functions (from Section 10)?

Does magic enable control, create hierarchy, or offer paths to subvert the institution's rules?

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Your Institution

Type of institution:	
Why they can't leave:	
The hierarchy/ranking system:	
Rules governing relationships:	
Who has power over them:	
Who might help them:	

Who threatens them:	
The gap between institutional ideal and reality:	
How they navigate/game the system:	

Final Thought

The best institutional settings feel alive, with their own rules, culture, corruption, and demands. The institution should press on your characters constantly, shaping what they can do, say, and feel.

Your characters don't just exist within institutions. They're shaped by them, rebel against them, find cracks in them, and ultimately either escape them or change them. Build an institution with enough grip that your characters can't just walk away, and then watch them try anyway. The institution creates the pressure; how your characters respond reveals who they truly are.

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